

WARMING UP to a New Deal

| By Raj Chengappa |

Jairam Ramesh was listening to jazz music on his iPod and staring at his laptop when Prime Minister Manmohan Singh called on his mobile. It was a Saturday morning, just two days before the crucial Climate Change Conference at Copenhagen was to begin and Ramesh, India's environment minister, had come into his office to clear some pending work. When he saw who the caller was, Ramesh leapt to attention, shut his iPod and listened respectfully.

The prime minister was calling to check whether he should confirm his attendance at the summit of 192 nations on December 18. A cautious Manmohan had kept everyone guessing as to his plans till there was some clarity about the way the summit was heading. Some of his advisers felt that given that industrialised countries were dragging their feet over enhanced emission targets it may be best if the prime minister kept away. Ramesh, though, was clear that given Manmohan's proactive approach on climate change, there was no need for him to be either passive or defensive. He told Manmohan: "Sir, your presence would make a huge difference and considerably strengthen India's stand. The world is looking towards your leadership on this issue and my humble advice is that you should attend."

Manmohan agreed. Ramesh couldn't wipe the smile off his face for a while. For the past six months he had battled almost single-handedly to change what he called India's "do-nothing" stand. He had deduced that it had outlived its usefulness and India was in danger of being branded the spoiler at the summit. So, with the tacit approval of the prime minister, he sent out a series of signals that India was ready for bold changes. That included putting on the table some form of voluntary emission cuts and even accepting international scrutiny for some of its climate change actions. India was now ready to negotiate at the high table.

The criticism came thick and fast from India's climate hardliners, who accused him of selling out to the West. Ramesh weaved his way out, though not without bruises. But if his initiative prevailed, albeit with some riders, it

Despite the flak, Jairam Ramesh pilots a nuanced shift in India's strategy on combating climate change. Deal making, not breaking, is the new mantra.



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was because it had the backing of the prime minister.

Manmohan had taken a keen personal interest in the negotiations leading up to Copenhagen. At home, he pushed through the National Action Plan on Climate Change that laid out eight proactive missions to help India combat the threat. In 2007, at the G-8 summit in Heiligendamm, Germany, Manmohan boldly announced that India's per capita Green House Gas (GHG) emissions would not exceed that of the developed countries at any point of time. India's per capita emission then stood at 1.2 tonnes as compared to that of 10.4 of Germany and 19.9 of the US. Much of the industrialised world thought it to be a clever ploy by India to avoid any legally binding cuts in its emissions that countries like the US were pushing for.

When Manmohan was re-elected as prime minister this May and Ramesh was made the environment minister, among the first things that Manmohan told him was, "Make sure that at the conclusion of the Copenhagen summit India is not isolated and accused of being a deal breaker". Ramesh was no stranger to the subject, having followed the climate change debate for decades, but events would soon set the pace for him. At the L'Aquila G-8 summit in Italy this July, world leaders agreed to work towards restricting global warming to within 2 degrees centigrade above pre-



“The announcement of unilateral emission cuts by Jairam Ramesh has weakened India's negotiating position.”

ARUN JAITLEY, MP, BJP